
Danger

*The Lord is like a strong tower
Those who do right can run to him for safety
Proverbs 18:10*

*Out of this nettle, danger
We pluck this flower: safety.
Shakespeare*

The first place is always better than the second place...

I once heard a San Diego policeman tell us one time that if you are ever attacked by someone run immediately because the first place is always better than the second. This means that if they are going to hurt you in public they will do much worse things in private.

He gave examples of time and time again where people were talked into going to another place and ended up having more harm done to them. He even said if someone was standing five feet away from you with a gun, that you should run. 80% of the people shooting will miss and over 90% won't shoot at all in public. His point was if they are crazy enough to shoot you in public, they would do much worse in private. How do you do this? Use the following:

If someone gets in your car for example in a mall, crash it right away right in the parking lot. Don't drive somewhere else.

Throw your money away and run in the other direction. If they want your money you will be okay. If they didn't, you have a head start.

If you are in a restaurant and someone comes in to hold it up; get up and run out right then and there. Don't wait.

Have a plan of where and when you are going to run with friends.
I know those sound crazy but he said it would save your life.

Consequences

*Remember this: The person who plants a little will have a small harvest,
But the person who plants a lot will have a big harvest.
2 Corinthians 9:6*

*You can do anything in this world if you're prepared to take the consequences.
W. Somerset Maugham*

For everything we do on this earth, and for some things that are done to us, we have consequences. Sometimes the consequences are good and sometimes they are bad. We can be sure that we will have consequences. As an adult, the consequences seem to get more serious, and we are in a position to have the opportunity to create more consequences and impact others as well.

As a child you get scolded by your parents, and if you are really, really bad you may go to military school. As an adult, no one scolds you, but if you are really bad you go to prison.

As a child, if you get in a car accident your parents pay.
As an adult, you pay and you may also get to go to prison.

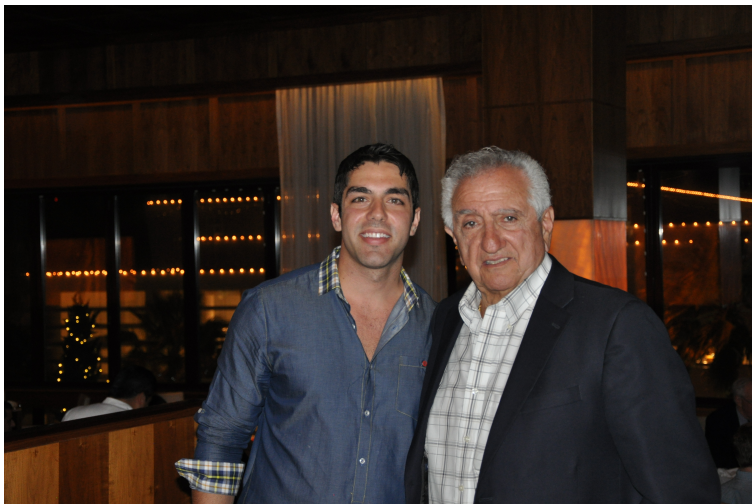
As a child if you win the lottery, your parents have to collect.
As an adult, you get to keep the money (minus 40% in taxes)

As a child, if I go to the wrong place I may be spanked or lost.
As an adult, if I go to the wrong place I may be raped or murdered.

You get the point. You have watched your dad reap the consequences of my actions; good and bad. You have seen how they have affected you; good and bad. What is really important to remember is that you can't always see and measure the consequences before the action you take. No matter how well thought out your actions may be you can never really measure all the consequences.

As you make decisions as an adult beware of the consequences good and bad. Take note of the impact your decisions will make.

Strike One...you're out.



.....
A fool always loses his temper, but a wise man holds it back.

Proverbs 29:11
.....

.....
The worst tempered people I've ever met were the people who knew they were wrong.

Wilson Mizner
.....

Don't ever EVER strike a women under any and all circumstances. Walk away. You will find that no one can get under your skin like the women you love. You won't get this till you are at that point but they can. I don't think you have the type of temper that would get to that point. If you find that you do; walk away. Get counseling, get help. Do whatever it takes.

If you ever do it once; you are done. She is gone and more than likely you are in jail.

Travel

For he looks to the ends of the earth and sees everything under heaven.

Job 28:24

***For my part, I travel not to go anywhere, but to go.
I travel for travel's sake. The great affair is to move.***

Robert Louis Stevenson

Travel anywhere and everywhere that you can. Very few things can help you grow to adulthood and continue to grow after that better than traveling. The more different people that you meet and see in their environments the better you can be. There is nothing more powerful than to see how other people, countries, families live to help you understand your experience better.

Your "world" is much smaller than when I grew up. With the internet the world is a much smaller place. Reach out and connect, you will be a better person for it.

Working Hard



***A person who does not work hard
Is just like someone who destroys things.***
Proverbs 18:9

It is better to wear out, than to rust out.
Richard Cumberland

Hard work (effort) requires no intelligence, money, advantage or connections. It just requires commitment and perseverance. Your ability to work hard for school will be a great advantage to you in life. You already know a key secret to success in life; working hard on the important things in your life. Someday you can use this to work hard on your marriage, raising your kids, staying connected to friends, your relationship with Christ just to name a few. You have talent and skills that when put to use with hard work and effort; you can do anything that you strive for.

Make sure that in the coming years you put your effort and priority into your relationship with Christ, your family, your health, your work/school and your friends. They are all important to you. When kept in this priority you will excel.

Embarrassment



.....
For you are my hope; O Lord God, you are my confidence from my youth.

Psalm 71:5

.....
If you're never scared or embarrassed or hurt, it means you never take any chances.

Julia Sorel

.....
Almost as destructive as fear, anger or arrogance is embarrassment controlling your life.

Embarrassment is an area that I have always struggled with that has been damaging to me. I can't tell you not to be embarrassed because that is almost impossible. Just don't let it control you. I can remember many instances where I missed out on doing things because I was embarrassed, or thought I would be embarrassed.

An example would be not asking a girl out because I was afraid to be embarrassed if she said no. It is kind of weird. I was not afraid of rejection but the embarrassment of people knowing I was rejected. Pretty sad, huh!

You know people that do not get embarrassed about anything. Maybe in some areas from your perspective or mine they should be. But should they? They don't let what other people think affect what they say, their friends, what they wear, what they like, etc. Seems like a lot less baggage for them than many people carry. The vast majority of feelings of embarrassment are false.

There are so many amazing things you will do and experience in life. Don't be held back because you fear embarrassment. It is not worth what you will miss.

Sex

Let us live in the right way, like people who belong to the day, We should not have wild parties and get drunk. There should be no sexual sin of any kind, no fighting or jealousy.

Romans 13:13

There is nothing like desire for preventing the thing one says from bearing any resemblance to what one has in one's mind.

Marcel Proust

The standard line is that “Guys are only after ONE thing.” They want sex and they will do anything to get a girl into bed. It is supposed to be different for Christians. I hope so but that is not always the case. You are a Christian guy and you have been told that sex is for marriage. The world tells you different. Is it okay to be a guy that is not after one thing? The answer is yes.

How do you make that happen?

Pick a girl that has the same values and expectations that you do. If you don't then you will end up being the one to “hold back” and that is a really tough position to be in.

If you do get in a great and strong relationship sex is not the NEXT step to a more mature relationship. It is not a step but a benefit of marriage. If you don't see it as a “step” to get closer or the next “stage” of a relationship then it won't be an option. Anyone that tells you that it is necessary, natural or required is lying to you. It is not a necessary step. Sex fogs everything. The desire for sex, is just as foggy as the actual sex in a relationship. Once it occurs, you can't think straight. You and your sexual purity is the one precious thing you can give to your wife. My expectations are that you want to marry a virgin. Your best hope is to be one yourself.

You don't need “experience” with sex before marriage. Trust me if you find the right girl; she will be ecstatic that you have “no experience”. There is no upside to being experienced with sex prior to marriage. You are not missing anything by playing the field. All you will do is feel bad later and have to carry the burden of other experience(s) if you have sex before marriage. You will have a stronger marriage if you wait.

Fear

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***The Lord is my light and the one who saves me.
I fear no one.***

***The Lord protects my life
I am afraid of no one.***
Psalms 27:1
.....

.....
Let me assert my firm belief that the only thing we have to fear is fear itself.
Franklin D. Roosevelt
.....

This is one word that will imprison you if don't fight it all the time. Be aware of when you are afraid, and as you have heard me say before: "Face your fears." I am sure that you know people that immediately come to mind when you think of fearful people.

Fear can wreck your life. People fear flying and never travel. People fear trusting people and never have loving relationships. People fear "not having a job" and stay in dead end positions and companies for the rest of their lives.

Don't let that happen to you. I am sure you are saying that you are not afraid to travel, etc. That is not the point. Don't let any fear hold you back. Recognize it and see it for what it is. Don't let fear control your life.

There is one thing to fear and that is God. The bible says, "Wisdom is the Fear of God." That is a fear you can have.

Jesus is Lord and Savior

***Jesus answered: I am the truth, the way, and the life
No one comes to the Father except through me.***

John 14:6

...that people often say about Him: "I'm ready to accept Jesus as a great moral teacher, but I don't accept His claim to be God." That is the one thing we must not say. A man who was merely a man and said the sort of things Jesus said would not be a great moral teacher. He would either be a lunatic--on a level with the man who says he is a poached egg--or else he would be the Devil of Hell. You must make your choice. Either this man was, and is, the Son of God: or else a madman or something worse. You can shut Him up for a fool, you can spit at Him and kill Him as a demon; or you can fall at His feet and call Him Lord and God. But let us not come with any patronizing nonsense about His being a great human teacher. He has not left that open to us. He did not intend to.

C. S. Lewis

The savior part is when you make a decision for Christ. You submit to His will. That is how you get to heaven.

The Lord part is much tougher. That is when you try to live your life to please Him. You do that because you recognize that it is by His sheer grace that you have the many blessings you have today. Your looks, brains, home, family, the fact that you live in the United States, etc. is all by the grace of God. You did nothing to get these; they were given to you. Lordship with Christ means that you recognize the following:

He is bigger than any problem or solution that you may have. Let me say that again: He is bigger than any problem or solution that you may have. Without centering your life on His standards, yours will move. Live by His standards. You do this to please Him. Since He designed everything you can feel confident knowing that "you" are working as designed!

Work to Live



***People can work hard using all their wisdom, knowledge and skill but they will die,
and***

***The other people will get the things for which they worked. They did not do
The work, but they will get everything. This is also unfair and useless.***

Ecclesiastes 2:21

***Perpetual devotion to what a man calls his business is only to be sustained by
perpetual neglect of many other things.***

Robert Louis Stevenson

Work to live don't live to work.

Simple concept. Figure it out early and you will be better for it. Make sure this is the way you live, your future wife lives, and that you teach this to your kids. I have met WAY too many workaholic successful men and women. They are successful but deep down they regret the time they have spent at work. Don't be like that.

Love Language

***It is better to correct someone openly
Than to have love and not show it.***

Proverbs 27:5

Love conquers all things; let us too surrender to love.

Virgil

Tell people, show people and remind people that you love them. For the people you love, tell them. This includes your future wife as well as your family. For example, make sure you tell your [sister Christine](#) that you love her. Tell your mom you love her; all the time.

Show the people you love that you love them. Everyone responds to a different love language. Harville Hendricks says there are five love languages. They are:

Words of Affirmation: Saying nice things

Gifts: Receiving gifts

Quality time: Spending time with them

Acts of Service: Doing things for them

Physical touch: Hugs, kisses (someday sex with your wife)

Everyone has a different love language. Some have more than one. Find out what they are!

PS; You can tell me you love me too!.

Arrogance

God can't stomach arrogance or pretense; believe me, he'll put those upstarts in their place.

Proverbs 16:5

By my count, more business leaders have failed and derailed because of arrogance than any other character flaw.

Harvey Mackey

There seems to be something about the world today that has fallen in love with arrogance.

The more successful you are the more accepting it is to be arrogant. Some people say "they are not arrogant", they are just confident. There is nothing wrong with confidence. We all need it.

The difference is when we begin to think that our own "poop" doesn't stink. We begin to think we are better than other people. It usually happens in areas that we had no control over from the start.

People are arrogant about where they live, the car they drive, how they look, their talents, how much money they have, etc. At your age, how many of these do you really have control over?

I really dislike arrogant people. They just really bug me. Make sure you can see the difference between confidence and arrogance.

Be confident. You have many reasons to be confident. Enjoy that but don't let it get out of hand and become arrogant.

Love and Favor

***The Lord has glory and majesty
He has power and beauty in His temple***

Psalm 96:6

***A thing of beauty is a joy forever
Its loveliness increases; it will never
Pass into nothingness***

John Keats

I have wrestled for a very long time with the notion of unconditional love. I am sure you remember us telling you that we love you unconditionally. That means that no matter what you do we will always love you. I love you and always will. I want to make a distinction between love and favor. You have heard the joke that I love you but I don't necessarily 'like' you. There is also "Love the sinner; hate the sin."

Going one step further, I can love you yet you may not have favor with me or your mother. It can also work the opposite as well. This means that for example if you are dis-respectful, not kind and loving to your mom, don't work to stay connected with your Sister, etc. do poorly in your college grades, get in trouble, etc. I will love you but you will not have favor with me. That might mean you get consequences i.e.. punishment etc. but it also might mean you don't get insurance for your car. I am sure you get the picture. What I am saying is that love is unconditional; favor is earned. Every day the way you act towards the people you love, your teachers, other adults, etc. you are earning or losing favor.

That may be obvious to you but I wanted you to see the difference. Earn favor from those you love and those you don't; the rewards will be great and life will be much easier

Manipulation

...know for sure that you will be punished for your sin.

Numbers 32:23

***All sin tends to be addictive, and the terminal point of addiction is what is called
damnation***

W.H. Auden

I know that is a pretty tough bible verse and quote, but this is an area that I really do think you and "everyone else" needs to watch out for. That area is manipulation.

Unfortunately you are very good at it. Sadly, so is everyone else, me included. "We" have learned (I am assuming this is a learned trait.) over many, many years and probably many successful outcomes to manipulate to get our way. Either you do not tell the whole story, add additional items, gauge when and where you communicate information, all with a goal to get your way, keep getting your way or avoid something you do not want. The reason it is so dangerous is that you are good at it and in many instances it works for you.

As you know, the problem is that it creates massive distrust with those whom you love and those that love you. People feel used and misled. The bigger issue is a loss of trust. Trust is something that you earn each and every day. It is like a bank account that you add to or subtract from. As a child, the consequence for manipulation has been loss of "stuff" like phones, computers, sleepovers and car time. All small things in the world of life all handed down by people (your Mom and Dad) who love you unconditionally no matter what you do or how you act.

In an adult world the consequences will be much worse such as loss of job and loss of relationships, and people that you hold dear. . Maybe even more important is that now as an adult you are building a reputation and a witness for all the world to see.

Make it a goal to be bad at manipulation. Quit practicing and get worse at this. The sooner the better.

Leadership

***A ruler without wisdom will be cruel,
But the one who refuses to take dishonest
Money will rule a long time.***
Proverbs 28:16

***The person who knows “how” will always have a job.
The person who knows “why” will always be his boss.***
Diane Ravitch

Companies rot from the top down. So do countries, towns and families. Leadership is everything. Having a bad leader is disastrous all the way around. Spiritually the provocative question is “Who leads your life, you or Jesus? If it is you, you are in trouble. If it is Christ; then there is hope for you.

Individually the question becomes whom are you leading today? Where are you leading them? Where are you going? You will have many opportunities to lead in the coming years. You have all the natural skills necessary to be a leader. I have heard you say (maybe jokingly or not) that you don’t want to be leader. You will be a leader of your family, friends or business some day. I am telling you that while the leader has more responsibility they have the best job, best pay, best perks, best schedule. Everyone else gets second best.

A president was once asked what he thought of his job at the company. After some thought he said the following: “It is not perfect by a long shot. However when I look around at all the other jobs in the company, this is by far the best one...”

Leaders are held to a higher standard. As an adult you will be called upon to lead. Step up and lead. You have all the skills and talent necessary. Don’t waste them.

Leadership is needed. You have the capability. Don’t pass it up.

New Rules

***He is strong and respected by the people
He looks forward to the future with joy.***

Proverbs 31:25

I have seen the future and it works.

Lincoln Steffens

Welcome to Being an Adult. This is you are a not a kid anymore lingo. We love you and always want you around but now that you are 18; you have more choices. Note: Just because you have the choice does not necessarily make it a good one...

KEVIN 18TH BIRTHDAY CHANGES

Old requirements

No vegetable requirements

No chores

No vacation or holiday requirements

You are always welcome at our house. (Now that you are 18; you are "free" if you want to be.) Anytime. For a day, week, month, years...

When we take a vacation, you are always welcome to join us for the vacation we are on. Note: We will always pay for the entire vacation if you take the entire vacation with us. (Example: We go to Nanny and Grandpa's for a week this summer. I will pay for you to come with us for the week. If you decide you only want to come for three days then you pay your own airfare.) I will always include you in the planning so you can make the vacation with us if you want.

New Requirements

If you come to visit/live, come because you want to be with us and don't be angry about it.

Examples of ways you show us you want to be with us: Eat some meals with us, talk with us, buys us dinner/lunch etc., go to the store or Starbucks with us, watch TV or a movie with us, etc.

You have no chores but come with an attitude to want to participate and help out. If when you come you only take, take, take and never give, you will wear out your welcome.

If you are staying with us and we go to church, we expect you to join with us.

If you stay with us, you will have a curfew that will go to 12:00pm unless rarely delayed for some unique reason.

More financial details to follow.

Being An Adult

***Don't stop listening to correction my child,
Or you will forget what you have already learned.***

Proverbs 19:27

***The future...something which everyone reaches at
The rate of sixty minutes and hour, whatever he does, whoever he is.***

C.S. Lewis

CONGRATULATIONS!

You are now once again the youngest as in the youngest adult there can be at 18 years of age. Just when you had made it to the top, you are right back at the beginning again. I am so very proud of you. 18 years of age and you have your entire life ahead of you to LIVE.

Live it well and live it as it should be because it is the only one you will ever have on this Earth. One of the ways you prepare for eternity is by living a full life here. I hope that one or two of the things I had to tell you will be of value to you now that you are 18. Take the very best and worst of all those around you, mix it in with the very best and worst of yourself these past 18 years and match it up against the Bible for a truth test and GO FOR IT.

You have such flexibility and such wide opportunity ahead. You can do so much. I saw a license plate the other day that said: If you are living as if there is not a God...you had better be right. That is true but it should read just the opposite. If you are living as if there is a God; you are right and ENJOY all that He has given you. You really have been given quite a bit in your first 18 years. You are blessed; you really are. You have so much still ahead of you. Don't be afraid to make a mistake. Don't be fearful. You are loved, cherished, prayed for, appreciated, approved of, accepted just the way you are.

My love for you is unconditional. It always has been and always will be. You already have done enough for me to love you with all my heart just by being born. You are precious, unique, special, loved, appreciated, significant, valuable, cherished and wanted. I am so very impressed with you. You have such talent, beauty, creativity, humor, confidence and intelligence. I have said this before...You are perfectly imperfect.

The problem is that it now means that I have a son that is 18 years of age and I think I am too young to have a son that old. You have given me an unbelievable 18 years. They have not all been perfect but at the same time, I feel incredibly proud to be your Dad.

Praying

***Lord hear my prayer; listen to my cry for mercy
Answer me because you are loyal and good.***

Psalm 143:1

One single grateful thought raised to heaven is the most perfect prayer.

G. E. Lessing

There is really one subject left that I need to share with you. It isn't the 52nd most important one; it is just the last one. I wanted to share with you how important it is for you to pray for everything that you do. I really believe that we all need "prayer cover." This means that we need people praying for us, and we need to be praying for others and ourselves.

Since the day I became a Christian, I have prayed for you unceasingly. It makes a difference and I want to encourage you to bring your challenges, hopes and dreams to God. Life is exciting and wonderful, but it is also very hard. You can't do it on your own, and you shouldn't try. Recognize your position, and recognize that it is by the grace of God we exist and breathe. It is easy to ask because He is worth asking.

I have enjoyed sharing these ideas with you. I also enjoy praying for you. I request that you pray for me as well. I need it. It is more important than sending me a birthday card or calling me on Father's Day.

Thank you for the past 18 years. God willing we will have many, many more years together.

I LOVE YOU, [Kevin](#) .